THE BENGAL TIGRESS

6 MAMATA BANERJEE, 68

CHIEF MINISTER, WEST BENGAL

BECAUSE Mamata is, simply, Mamata—an unfathomable reservoir of energy and political flamboyance. Her Trinamool Congress may have lost national party status, West Bengal may be getting stifled of MNREGA and PMAY funds by New Delhi, and a sword of Damocles may hang over her party in terms of cases, but no one since Jyoti Basu has ever made the mistake of writing her off politically

BECAUSE she has given the call for a "*poribartan* (change)" at the Centre in 2024, linking it to the one that swept out 34 years of Left rule in Bengal in 2011. She had posed the TMC as the vanguard of an Opposition phalanx. That idea has dimmed a bit in the wake of a Congress revival, but her grandstanding against the BJP assures Mamata a front seat in any tie-up

WHAT'S COOKING She loves to cook and often indulges guests with her culinary expertise. Fish specialities are said to be her forte. Besides, she has a weakness for chocolates

BECAUSE her mercurial posturing hides a razor-sharp tactical brain. She even made capital out of the Ramnavami tensions in Howrah and Rishra, making an adequate amount of noise on the BJP's aggressive Hindutva. Just before that, the Sagardighi bypoll had indicated Muslim voters were moving away from the TMC. She's not one to sit by and watch something like that happen

7 NITISH KUMAR, 72

CHIEF MINISTER, BIHAR

Opposition Glue

BECAUSE Mr Dependable is adept at political cross-stitching. Having bridged the gap between the Congress and other Opposition parties, Nitish has emerged as the crucial adhesive needed to cobble together an anti-BJP front before the 2024 LS poll

BECAUSE in August 2022 when Nitish dumped the BJP and joined hands with the RJD, Congress and others to form an alternative government in Bihar, he gave the saffron party, the reigning champion at toppling governments, a taste of their own medicine

SWEET SPOT Careful about his sugar intake otherwise, he's partial towards rasgullas. A shop in Lajpat Nagar, Delhi, is a particular fave

BECAUSE while Nitish pooh-poohs suggestions about him being a possible PM candidate, he may emerge as the dark horse after the LS poll if the numbers stack up in a particular manner



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE